

Jeremy Lent: A Paradigm For A Better Future [B2]

Considerato da molti uno dei più grandi pensatori della nostra epoca, propone la sua idea di “civiltà ecologica”, dove umani, natura ed economia convivono in armonia.

With [political turmoil](#) around the world and scientists [warning](#) about the inevitable and devastating effects of climate change, few of us doubt that this century [will](#) see some kind of major transition. Where that transition [will](#) take us is impossible to predict, but hope and inspiration can be found in the work of writer and integrator Jeremy Lent.

LIFE CHANGES

Born and brought up in the UK, after a first [degree](#) at Cambridge University, Jeremy moved to the United States to continue his studies before [going into business](#). Although successful, in 2000 he was forced to sell his company in order to stay at home and look after his wife, who was terminally ill and sadly [passed away](#). Jeremy describes how, after this series of deep personal shocks, he decided that, whatever he did with the rest of his life, he wanted it to be [meaningful](#). Since then, he has dedicated himself to an academic, intellectual and personal search for meaning. The [Patterning](#) Instinct (2017) and The Web of Meaning (2021) by Jeremy Lent.

TWO BOOKS

The result has been two books: The [Patterning](#) Instinct (2017) and The Web of Meaning (2021). These books have led climate activist George Monbiot, as well as many others, to describe Jeremy Lent as “one of the greatest thinkers of our age.” The [Patterning](#) Instinct is a tour de force study of the history of humanity in [terms](#) of culture, biology and psychology. It considers every possible influence — from the birth of language, religion and agriculture to

art, commerce, science and technology — in order to better understand exactly how we arrived where we are today. People

Sheehan Quirke: The Cultural Tutor Il suo scopo è rendere la cultura stimolante e alla portata di tutti. Per farlo, ha iniziato dalle reti sociali, grazie alle quali ha raggiunto migliaia di persone. Daniel Francis

UNCLE BOB

Lent describes his second book, *The Web of Meaning*, as a long answer to an archetypal Uncle Bob — a [relative](#) or [acquaintance](#) we all have, whom he characterises as follows: **Jeremy Lent (English accent):** If you can imagine if you're in a [tea party](#), like a family party, and people are talking and somebody's saying, "You know, the world can be different. We can make a better world. There's all these things we can do and should do." And then Uncle Bob [comes along](#) into the conversation. And Uncle Bob is this person; we all know Uncle Bob, there's always an Uncle Bob in our own families. And we all [have Uncle Bob within us](#) a little bit, too. But Uncle Bob [comes along](#) and says, "Let me tell you about it. When you've been around the world like I have, you kind of know that actually, all human beings are [selfish](#), and it's a [rat race](#) out there. And nature is just basically a matter of all these [selfish](#) genes fighting against each other, and humans [turned out](#) to be successful because we're better at being competitive than the others. And the reason capitalism works is because it takes all that competitiveness and [harnesses](#) it to make everybody more efficient. And that's just the way it is, and we've got a few problems, sure, but this is the best way to solve things... is just by allowing our [selfish](#)ness and capitalism to do its thing." And everyone kind of [shuts down](#), and that's the end of the conversation, right? Because what do you say to that?

THE HEDONIC TREADMILL

According to Jeremy, the whole world seems to agree with Uncle Bob. In fact, we're taught right from our school years that the most important values in life are prestige, financial success, and status. School has been designed with

the ultimate goal of turning people into the most efficient little cogs in a destructive machine that makes money for a wealthy elite, instead of helping people to achieve a sense of real fulfilment in their lives. **Jeremy Lent:** The problem is, with that way of living, sometimes called the 'hedonic treadmill'. Obviously, we all know what a treadmill is, and the hedonic part means it's always wanting us to feel that next bit of momentary pleasure. But the next time you feel it, you always then want the next one and the next one, so you're never satisfied. And again, I think the opportunity is, each person has to come to their own moment of recognising that something's wrong, recognising that this is actually not giving them deeper pleasure.

THE HEDONISTIC TREADMILL

The treadmill or treadwheel was introduced into prisons in 1818 by the British engineer Sir William Cubitt (1785-1861). It was a long wooden cylinder with metal framing and with metal steps on the exterior. The idea was to occupy the inmates of the prison in a useful way: if a prisoner put his weight onto one step, it moved downwards, turning the cylinder, so the prisoner would be forced to move onto the step above in a kind of infinite staircase. The energy produced by the turning cylinder could be used, for example, to grind grain into flour. It was extremely hard work for the prisoners, and to this day we often say we have to 'go back to the treadmill' if we have to return to a job we don't like after the weekend or a holiday.

COLLAPSE OR TECHNO SPLIT

Jeremy believes that if we continue on our current path, striving for greater and greater success with more and more consumption and production, and measuring our growth with false measurements such as GDP, there will be three possible outcomes. The first scenario is the terrible possibility of the total collapse of our civilisation. The second is what he terms the 'techno split': **Jeremy Lent:** There's another scenario — I call that 'techno split' — which I think sometimes the elites secretly are expecting, which is similar to that first scenario, but it's almost like a bifurcation of the human species where most people in the world do suffer some sense of collapse, a collapse

of just any kind of normal way of living life, any kind of decent life. But this other small elite section, the ones that have their private jets and live in these kind of fortress communities right now, and basically keep themselves separated from everything else, they [end up](#) maintaining that sense of separation, and [end up](#) even genetically [figuring out](#) how to become superhumans, and have some sort of techno utopia where they even [enhance](#) their own cognition and become part of some different kind of species entirely.

A THIRD WAY

The third scenario is one of true [flour](#)ishing, which Jeremy and many others are calling 'an ecological civilisation'. This is a scenario where we learn to live in balance and our economy, our technology, and in fact our whole civilisation are designed not to just consume, but to actually create the conditions for all human beings to [flour](#)ish on a regenerated earth. But is it possible? **Jeremy Lent:** I believe it is, but the only way we're going to get to that place is if we transform the very [foundations](#) of our society right now. If we transform this growth-based capitalist system of extraction and exploitation to one that actually doesn't even have to look that different. We'll still have cities, we'll still have marketplaces, we'll still have technology and industry, and all the things that we actually really want and care about. But we'll be able to live in this way where we all get to share in the abundance, where we actually have abundance that's more publicly there for people to share rather than privately-owned behind big [fences](#). And this is possible, but it involves looking at some of these deep [underlying](#) structural [flaws](#) of our current civilization and having the political [will](#) to change them. An [oil spill](#) raises [GDP](#) because of the cost of cleaning it up.

REACHING OUT TO YOUNG PEOPLE

With pressure from school, parents and [peers](#) to be successful in life, not to mention the influence of advertising and social media, it can be hard for young people to escape from the [hedonic treadmill](#). But Jeremy has some [advice](#): **Jeremy Lent:** The most important thing we can do for our children is

to offer them the love that, as all human beings [do], they really want. To give them that secure foundation from which they themselves can learn to be curious, and learn to love themselves, and ultimately want themselves to feel fulfilled. As our children get older, I think one of the most important things we can do is really get them to understand they don't have to get onto that [hedonic treadmill](#). That they can be happy by really looking into themselves and [truly](#) fulfil their sense of who they are as people, and whatever that might be, however low status that might be in our dominant culture, to actually go ahead and [pursue](#) that, and know that they can be loved by doing that. And I think if they can approach life in that way, then they [will](#) naturally [end up](#) really contributing to that movement towards an ecological civilisation, a [life-affirming](#) civilisation.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Anyone hoping for a positive outcome may feel [overwhelmed](#) by the task ahead and a sense of terrible impotence, but The Web of Meaning is full of positive possibilities and Jeremy has some practical [advice](#): **Jeremy Lent**: The thing that I would invite people to do is to realise that the future that's [unfolding](#) is not a spectator sport. It's not like we're going into the stadium, supporting our team to win against the other. It's actually something that we [are all engaged in](#) ourselves. So every one of us together, by the decisions we make, the acts that we do, are actually co-creating the future ourselves. And once we begin to realise that, and we get to see that we don't feel so [powerless](#), we actually can do something. None of us alone are going to change things in a way that we can see [measurably](#). But as part of something bigger, we're all going to [make a difference](#). And that brings a sense of both freedom, that none of us is going to be the one to be the saviour to change it all, but also a sense of responsibility.

WHAT IS [GDP](#) GOOD FOR?

[Gross Domestic Product](#) ([GDP](#)) is the primary, standard, and most common economic indicator used to measure the total market value of all final goods and services produced within a country. It was developed in the 1930s by

economist Simon Kuznets, who immediately warned that it was “a potentially dangerous oversimplification that could be [misleading](#)” and “vulnerable to abuse.” The central problem with [GDP](#) as a measure of a country’s economic performance is that it does not distinguish between activities that promote [welfare](#) and those that diminish it. Under [GDP](#) accounting, any increase in economic activity — whether beneficial or [harmful](#) — adds to the total. An [oil spill](#), for example, raises [GDP](#) because of the cost of cleaning it up. In the description of one team of analysts: “By the curious standard of the [GDP](#), the nation’s economic hero is a terminal cancer patient who is going through a costly divorce. The happiest event is an [earthquake](#) or a hurricane.” www.jeremylent.com

Glossary

- **have Uncle Bob within us** = avere dentro di noi
- **shuts down** = bloccarsi
- **foundations** = fondamenta, basi
- **advice** = consiglio
- **truly** = veramente
- **metal framing** = struttura metallica
- **staircase** = scala
- **enhance** = migliorare, potenziare
- **hedonic treadmill** = tapis roulant edonico
- **on our current path** = su questa strada
- **terms** = definire, chiamare
- **relative** = parente
- **flour** = farina
- **harmful** = dannosa
- **oil spill** = sversamento di petrolio
- **warning** = avvertire
- **split** = divisione, frattura
- **earthquake** = terremoto
- **cogs** = ingranaggi
- **downwards** = verso il basso
- **flaws** = difetti
- **life-affirming** = vitale
- **Gross Domestic Product** = Prodotto Interno Lordo
- **welfare** = benessere
- **figuring out** = capire
- **are all engaged in** = essere coinvolto in
- **selfish** = egoisti
- **turned out** = rivelarsi
- **peers** = pari, colleghi
- **political turmoil** = instabilità politica
- **passed away** = morire
- **acquaintance** = conoscente
- **rat race** = competizione spietata

- **steps** = scalini
- **inmates** = detenuti
- **GDP** = PIL (gross domestic product)
- **underlying** = sottostanti
- **grind** = macinare
- **unfolding** = dispiegarsi
- **make a difference** = fare la differenza
- **powerless** = impotenti
- **meaningful** = significativa
- **comes along** = presentarsi, arrivare
- **striving** = impegnarsi
- **outcomes** = esiti
- **Patterning** = modellare, seguire degli schemi
- **tea party** = festicciola, riunione informale
- **end up** = finire per
- **fences** = recinzioni
- **degree** = laurea
- **going into business** = dedicarsi al mondo degli affari
- **harnesses** = incanalare
- **pursue** = perseguire
- **misleading** = fuorviante
- **fulfilment** = realizzazione personale
- **will** = volontà
- **overwhelmed** = sopraffatto
- **measurably** = in modo misurabile